

Foundations of Music Theory

Chapter 1: Pitch and Notation

1.1 The Staff and Clefs

The staff consists of five horizontal lines and four spaces. Each line and space represents a different pitch. A clef placed at the beginning of the staff assigns specific pitch names to those lines and spaces, so that the same symbol can stand for a high or a low register.

1.2 Accidentals

An accidental is a symbol that raises or lowers the pitch of a note. A sharp raises a note by one semitone, a flat lowers a note by one semitone, and a natural cancels a previously applied sharp or flat for the remainder of the measure.

Chapter 2: Rhythm and Meter

2.1 Note Durations

In common time a whole note lasts four beats. A half note lasts two beats, a quarter note lasts one beat, and an eighth note lasts half of one beat. Each smaller value divides the beat above it exactly in two.

2.2 Time Signatures

A time signature is written as two stacked numbers. The upper number states how many beats occur in each measure, and the lower number states which note value is counted as a single beat. Together they fix the metrical pulse of the music.